

A letter from the Editor:

Dear Reader,

Welcome to the September issue of Hanna's Happenings! This month I've cooked up another food-themed issue, albeit a few days late.

It has been a busy season of celebrating and travelling, but I still found time to have fun in the kitchen this summer and early autumn. Looking back, I realised how much of what I cooked was started by or shared with someone else. My aunt gave me a portion of her sourdough starter. Our neighbours gifted us a few pounds of super spicy chili peppers. My parents spent years evolving our family crab dinner on the Washington coast into a full-on seafood boil, and in August I recreated it at a beach near home for my friends.

Traditions last because people pass them on and change them to suit the needs and limitations of the moment. A sourdough starter is a living culture that can be shared, but in a new kitchen it becomes something distinct, shaped by the flour, temperature, and possibly even the baker's hands and microbiome. The same goes for a method or a recipe. My parents' boil looks quite different from the crabbing-dock dinners of my childhood, and I rarely follow a recipe to the letter myself. Adapting and improvising on old themes is what "food culture" means to me, and it's at the heart of this month's newsletter.

Thank you for reading about and sharing in my food culture. I'd love it if you forwarded this issue to a friend or sent me a message about what you've been cooking lately

With love,

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Hanna Clements". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Hanna" and the last name "Clements" clearly distinguishable.



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September Food Issue | Hanna's Happenings



Summer Seafood Boils

A table heaped with steaming seafood is a delight to behold, and it's made even better when it is crowded with friends and family. I was lucky enough to enjoy two such seafood boils this year.

In recent years my family has revived our annual trip to the Washington coast. It's always been one of my favorite vacations, and one of the traditions I look forward to most is our seafood dinner night. In eras past, my parents hauled us kids, our pets, and all kinds of equipment, smelly bait included, to the crabbing docks so we could bring in a catch to cook up back at camp.

INGREDIENTS

- Dungeness Crab Clusters
- Steamer Clams
- Mussels
- Prawns
- Andouille Sausage
- Baby Potatoes
- Corn on the Cob
- Onion
- Old Bay™ Seasoning

These days, with busy schedules leading to shorter trips, we keep the sourcing simpler and leave the catching and cleaning to the professionals. But we've made up for it by amping up our crab dinner to an elaborate seafood boil. Over the past few years my parents have developed a perfect setup to prepare the boil in our campsite, which may involve an industrial propane burner.

One of my goals for this summer was to share this tradition with my community here at home. So one day late in August I gathered some friends at my favorite local beach to recreate the experience. It ended up being a highlight of my summer (and of course the food was fantastic). A few weeks later, I got to do the whole thing again with my family back in the place where the tradition started.

Fermentation Station Update

My fermentation station is staying active! Lately it's been filled with a mix of my go-to ferments, along with some new projects.

Garlic Ginger Paste

In February I shared my method for preparing garlic ginger paste. The astute reader will notice that I tend to set up this fermentation experiment in September, and it's not by accident.

In my experience, the quality of the ingredients is one of the major factors that dictate the outcome (i.e. deliciousness) of a ferment. Garlic is generally harvested from late July to early September in the Pacific

Northwest, so it's prime time to set up garlic-based ferments. I also find that the cooler weather leads to more controllable, better-tasting ferments, and fewer overflows and *Lactobacillus* bombs.

A friend and I got together to peel and crush a cuticle-disintegrating quantity of some beautiful local purple-striped "Russian Red" garlic (about 1 pound in total). I'll let the garlic ferment with ginger at room temperature for about three months before I move it to the refrigerator and begin using it in my day-to-day cooking.

Super Hot Sauce

Our neighbours generously gave us a few pounds of flaming hot chili peppers. Delicious but deadly, I decided the best thing to do with the peppers was to ferment them with a few cloves of the leftover garlic. I recently blended them into one of the hottest sauces I've ever made!

So Much Sourdough

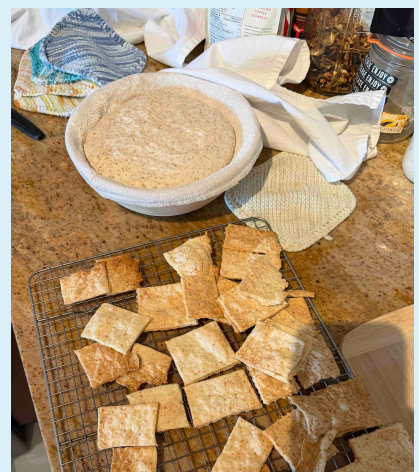
This summer my aunt gave me some of her sourdough starter,



marking a new stage in my love affair with bread.

I've been churning out loaves and working on my technique for a few months now. Although I'm still learning, I feel like I'm finally starting to get consistent results.

Perhaps even better than the bread itself are the recipes for using the sourdough discard. For example, we refer to King Arthur's sourdough discard crackers simply as "crack".



Summer Berry Bounty

In the [Spring Foraging Issue](#) I shared my excitement for berry season. Throughout the long, hot days of summer I made good on this enthusiasm and got out to pick berries on several occasions. Most often I foraged invasive Himalayan blackberries (*Rubus armeniacus*) near my apartment. I used the berries in all sorts of recipes and dishes, including a fruity baked brie with blackberries, blueberries, peaches, and figs. I also took advantage of the harvest season by developing a new recipe to preserve the bounty, inspired by the food I dehydrated for my summer backpacking.



Homemade Fruit Leather

This fruit leather recipe is endlessly customizable and makes a great, shareable hiking snack. Because it's prepared in bulk, I opt for cheaper fruit options, like frozen cut fruits or foraged berries.

Combine all the ingredients in a large pot and cook down until the mixture thickens, 20 to 45 minutes. For less watery fruits like mangoes, you can skip this step. Blend the mixture, then pour it onto parchment-lined dehydrator or baking trays and dehydrate. I ran my dehydrator at 125 °F for 8 to 14 hours, depending on the initial hydration level of the mixture.

INGREDIENTS

- 4 quarts berries or chopped fruit (fresh or frozen)
- 1/2 to 2 cups sugar, to taste
- Pinch of salt
- Splash of juice or citric acid (optional, to taste)
- Spices or vanilla extract (optional)

Sweet Treat of the Month

[Recipe by PJ Hamel \(King Arthur Flour\)](#)

To round out this month's issue, I'm sharing a recipe I've had on repeat: King Arthur Flour's Fudge Brownies.

I've always been a brownie lover (in grade school I often asked for them as my birthday treat to share with the class). I tested several from-scratch brownie recipes before I found one that I liked better than boxed mix. The richness from the espresso powder and the solid texture of the cooled chocolate chips are what take this recipe to the next level. I like to slightly modify the recipe by adding a sprinkle of chocolate chips and flaky salt to the top of the batter right before baking for even more texture.

